Given that the freedom enjoyed by the Church translated to freedom to prevail over earthly rulers as well, it expectedly led to strained relations between the Roman Catholic Church headed by the pope and earthly authorities. Even the common people, the lowest in the spiritual hierarchy of Christianity, resented the sanctimonious intervention of a hierarchically organised Catholic Church in all facets of life. The constant sermons to overcome sin and to repent for it contributed to a general distrust of the Christian clergy, while their own ability to rise above the very sin they preached against was called into question. Ironically, this did not translate to loss of faith in Christianity; instead, the lay believers organised themselves in private groups to circumvent the overarching influence of the Church and drew inspiration instead from the monastic orders that had influenced the Church itself. However, since it was impossible for the lay believer to observe all the rigours of a monastic life, the process of conversion for which monastic orders had been created spilled over into the society and acquired a life of its own, thereby inching towards the Protestant Reformation. De Roover calls it the ‘monasticisation of daily life’, which prepared the ground for a confrontation with the Roman Catholic Church. After all, the Church’s monopoly over sin and penitence was being seriously undermined owing to the secularisation, rather de-Churchification, of conversion and reform, the very pillars of Christian belief—the raison d’être of the Church.

What made matters worse for the Church was the fact that people were willing to believe the accounts and stories of lecherous priests, and the Church itself began to be seen as the biggest obstacle to the practise of true Christian faith. No longer were the Church and its clergy seen as the sole conduits to God, nor were they treated as exclusive or special beneficiaries of divine grace. This empowered the lay believer’s ability to pursue his or her own faith through individual and direct submission to God without any form of ecclesiastical intercession. This was the bedrock of the approach of the Protestant Reformation to Christianity. To digress on a related note, those who are familiar with the origins of anti-Brahmin attitudes in Bharat after the arrival of the European coloniser, would be able to draw parallels between the Protestant Reformation’s grievances with the Roman Catholic Church and the projection of similar grievances onto institutions, practices and groups in Bharat that were seen as ‘Brahminical’. As we shall see in the next section, the Protestant lens led the Christian European coloniser to